

GIREESH GV



The Great Call of China

BANGALORE Karnataka legislators have something to look forward to—a 10-day study tour to China, that too at the state Government's expense. The Rs 2.5-crore all-party junket to study "swift development methods adopted by China in key areas like agriculture, urban development, health, education and infrastructure" will be undertaken at a time when 13 districts in the central and northern parts of the state are battling

heavy rains and floods, while six districts are reeling under drought.

Had the high court not postponed them in the wake of the floods, the tour dates would also have coincided with the state election commission's decision to conduct elections to urban local bodies on August 30.

Legislators like Saleem Ahmed justify the trip saying it would help them understand how China has undertaken development. Legislator Dinesh Gundu

LAST LEG: Kumaraswamy with legislators

Rao says such tours are eye-openers for those who haven't seen the developed world. "Half of the world's concrete is being poured into China's construction projects and a third of global steel production is going to high rises in Beijing, Shanghai and other cities in China," points out Rao, defending the tour.

However, both Chief Minister H.D. Kumaraswamy and his deputy B.S. Yediyurappa, who had been planning junkets to China and Europe to seek investments, have chosen to remain mum on the issue. "It is up to the legislators to decide as this trip was planned by the assembly Speaker," says Kumaraswamy. The reason behind this silence is the fact that only two months are left for JD(S) to transfer power to BJP and both the chief minister and his deputy cannot afford to antagonise anyone. Politics, clearly, is a strange trip.

by Stephen David

A New Platform

LONDON TV Today Network, India's premier news network, made its British foray with the launch of its flagship 24-hour Hindi news channel, Aaj Tak last week. Members of the Indian and Pakistani high commissions in London and well-heeled South Asians mingled with global media at a champagne reception at the Sony



Krishnan in London (centre)

Headquarters in central London's Golden Square. In keeping with the spirit of the moment, the announcement came as a video clip of a breaking news spoof.

Aaj Tak has been launched as part of Max Mix, the leading platform for South Asian entertainment in the UK. Speaking on the occasion, G. Krishnan, CEO and executive director, TV Today said, "After the US, the Middle East and continental Europe, the UK is the next logical step for us. Launching Aaj Tak on the Max Mix platform will offer the viewers with live news and analysis from home right into their living room." Aroon Purie, chairman and MD of TV Today said, "Aaj Tak has been able to successfully widen the viewership base for news in India. Combined with our launch in the US and Europe, this step will widen the base for Indian news internationally."

by Aditi Khanna

OBJECT OF DESIRE

Notable Arrival

HP COMPAQ 2710P NOTEBOOK
Rs 1.25 lakh

Hewlett-Packard's new notebook, weighing 1.65 kg with a width of 29.1 mm, is a slim beauty. With a 100 GB HDD and 2048 MB DDR2 (upgradeable to 4096 MB) memory, it packs in a punch with high definition audio and touch sensitive controls. The screen features an outdoor display panel which improves viewability in sun. Its dual-microphone array and 2 mega pixel camera make web conferencing and video-enhanced instant messaging quite easy.

